

Architecture Before Technology: the checklist

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Decide the structure first; then the technology questions answer themselves. Answer these five questions before the first item is created, in this order: each answer makes the next one easier. Sources: Microsoft Learn, checked on 2026-09-29.

#	Decide first	Architecture answer	Why it works in Fabric	Month-six sentence it prevents
1	Where does it live?	One workspace per domain and stage; core data domains (Finance data) and consumer domains (Sales reports)	The workspace is the unit for roles, Git and deployment pipelines; domains group a team's workspaces for the OneLake catalog	"Where is the current version?"
2	How do others read it?	One path Bronze, Silver, Gold in the core data domain; consumers get a shortcut to Gold, never a copy	A shortcut points to the data instead of copying it; changes are visible at once, and the reader's capacity pays for its reads	"Which revenue number is right?"
3	What competes for compute?	Separate capacity by workload: scheduled jobs, reports, Dev and Test	Throttling is per capacity: when one is overloaded, the others aren't slowed by its load. On an overloaded capacity, the reports people open are delayed, then rejected first	"Why is it slow on Monday?"
4	How does it reach Prod?	Git, then fabric-cicd to Test and Prod; nobody edits Prod	Git integration works per workspace. Data never travels, connections do: fabric-cicd swaps IDs per stage with a parameter file, schedules live in the item definition, post-deploy actions run the refresh. Microsoft recommends fabric-cicd as a best practice	"Who changed Prod?"
5	Who says yes to access?	Owner per domain, roles in OneLake: the owner approves groups; readers get Viewer plus a OneLake role on Gold (tables, rows, columns)	Access comes from workspace roles, not the domain; OneLake rules are authored once and enforced across Fabric engines	"Who can see this report?"

Also: name workspaces {Domain}-{Env}-{Purpose} (Finance-Prod-Data, Sales-Dev-Reports, Finance-Prod-Reports), agreed before the first workspace. Write an ADR per architecture decision (decision, why, alternatives, date, owner, status), superseded, never edited, versioned in Git.

Then the technology question: Lakehouse or Warehouse?

My recommendation: Lakehouse, Lakehouse, Lakehouse for Bronze, Silver and Gold.

- **Change data feed:** switch it on for the Delta tables in a lakehouse, and the next layer can read only the rows that changed. Materialized lake views use the same change feed for incremental refresh. Set `delta.enableChangeDataFeed = true` when you create the table; it doesn't backfill.
- **Shortcuts:** they land in a lakehouse, so every layer shares without copies.
- **One permission model:** the OneLake roles from answer 5 cover every layer. A Gold Warehouse adds a second model: its T-SQL security applies to SQL queries only.
- **Take a Warehouse** where Gold needs T-SQL writes, stored procedures or multi-table transactions. Same Delta in OneLake, same SQL engine: add it later without moving data.

On Monday: ask the five questions about your own platform; the first one without a clear answer is where to start.

Links

- Everything from the session: <https://github.com/TheTrustedAdvisor/fabcon-europe-2026>
- Fabric deployment patterns: https://learn.microsoft.com/azure/architecture/data-guide/technology-choices/fabric-deployment-patterns?wt.mc_id=AZ-MVP-5003447
- fabric-cicd and CI/CD best practices: https://learn.microsoft.com/fabric/fundamentals/understand-best-practices-fabric-cicd?wt.mc_id=AZ-MVP-5003447
- OneLake security, row and column level: https://learn.microsoft.com/fabric/onelake/security/table-column-row-security?wt.mc_id=AZ-MVP-5003447
- Change data feed with Delta tables: https://learn.microsoft.com/fabric/data-engineering/delta-lake-change-data-feed?wt.mc_id=AZ-MVP-5003447
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